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CREATIVE WRITING AS A TEACHING STRATEGY TO EFFECT POSITIVE CHANGES IN PRIMARY SCHOOL PUPILS IN NIGERIA

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Abstract

Primary education has been, and always will be, the cornerstone of all other education. It should be crucial to use a variety of instructional techniques to educate students starting in primary school, and creative writing is something that cannot be disregarded. Creative writing is one of the most engaging ways to educate young brains. There are four essential skills in English. Speaking, writing, listening, and reading are these. And among the most useful abilities is writing. In the twenty-first century, writing is a common method of communication. The finest method for helping pupils become better writers is through creative writing. Studying creative writing is a fascinating subject that is crucial to the growth of language acquisition skills. It originates only from within and develops into something far more valuable, intelligent, and essential to the educational setting. The world is a creative place, full of natural resources for the

Introduction

Creativity, in general, is defined by Boden (2001, p. 95) as, the skill of coming out with new ideas that are surprising, intelligible, and valuable in some way. Creativity is essential to innovation, novelty, and sustenance (Kaplan, 2019). In general, Salvi and Bowden (2016) define creativity as the ability to come up with new ideas that are amazing, understandable, and somewhat valuable. Creativity is essential for innovation and delivery (Vally, Salloum et al. 2019). According to Parks, and Schueller (2013), writing is not just a way to express happiness, it is a way to learn and teach others. Writing is a creative ability, according to Alviano, and Oktawati (2021) they said that it creates rather than receives a language. Creative writing is more than just a passion; it is a craft for practising, individual writing awareness, and following effective writing processes all play decisive roles in producing written texts (Larkin, 2009). Creative writing goal is not just assisting and enabling learning; it can also provide

Creative mind, and open to anyone with a flair for language. The finest plays, essays, poetry, and fiction written anywhere represent the pinnacle of the purely creative writing abilities that playwrights and authors hone in addition to their other foundational abilities. Therefore, it is a fantastic fit for the learners to adapt to readily when this creative writing is used in elementary school. This paper elaborated on how creative writing can be used as a teaching strategy to effect positive changes in primary school pupils in Nigeria. Consequently, this research suggests that creative writing ought to be required at the level of primary school, teachers should continue to develop their creative writing skills, and a comfortable learning atmosphere should always be available.

Keywords: Creative Writing, Teaching Strategy, Primary School, Pupils, Nigeria.

alternative ways of expressing and demonstrating teaching (Everett, 2005). Teaching creative writing encourages students to write by drawing upon their imaginations, and other creative processes may support writing development in all its components as suggested by (Barbot, Tan, Randi, Donato & Grigorenko, 2012). To enhance students' writing skills, teachers should encourage and motivate students to practice to become familiar with writing in English as a foreign/second language (Pentury et al., 2020). There is a tendency for learners to rely on their first language when they practice writing skills, owing to the low level of their English (Alkhaldi & Benaggoun, 2015). The writing process consists of several steps: planning, drafting, and revising. The teacher's role is to give students feedback and enable them to master such techniques and improve their learning autonomy (Barkaoui, 2007). According to Pentury et al. (2020), planning, drafting, revising, and editing constitute the four steps in creative writing. These steps can also be used in other types of writing, including academic work.

For creative writing to take place. Creativity in a classroom must be promoted, where pupils are grouped for specific purposes, rather than randomly, and are offered controlled product choices that make sense in the content area. Creative 1esson components are not just fee1- good activities they directly address critical content target specific standards and require thoughtfu1 products that allow students to show what they know. In the creative classroom, the teacher encourages students to become independent learners by using strategies such as the gradua1 re1ease of responsibility mode1 (Fisher &Frey, 2008). Torrance, (2003) a pioneer in creativity research, concluded that too much pressure on children to 1earn academic subjects tends to prematurely stifle fantasy (T0rrance, 2003). He also set forth five principles that teachers should follow to develop creativity, that is, treat children's questions and ideas with respect; and treat usual ideas with respect. Show

children their ideas have value; provide opportunities for se1f-initiated learning and provide periods of non-eva1uated practice (no forma1 testing, nor a need for it in the wa1dorf schools) additi0na1 recent research has shown that forced learning can affect not on1y the chi1d's learning potentia1s but his emotiona1 and socia1 stabi1ity.

Teachers must be more innovative and improve their teaching techniques if they want to employ creative writing to help pupils in primary school experience good changes.

THE DIAGRAM BELOW SHOWS DETAILED STEPS OF THE WRITING PROCESS

CONCEPTUALIZATION

Writing Skills

Writing is characterized by a variety of differences. Writing is a deliberate, social interaction that also includes literacy (Tan & Miller, 2008). Writing can only be viewed from the point of view of a group instead of an individual (Burke, 2010).

Writing skills are associated with creativity, which means the ability to produce new ideas that are high in quality and task-appropriate (Sternberg, 2000). Similarly, Boden (2001) opines that creative skills entail generating novel ideas that are intelligible, valuable, and surprising. Writing has an impact on the development of creative thinking skills and the language learning process itself (Alkhaldi, 2019), and technological tools can facilitate the learning process and provide students with

opportunities to improve their thinking skills (Masterson, 2020) and other language skills, such as writing, grammatical items, and lexical items.

Creative Writing

Creative Writing plays an important role in developing learners' writing skills, for academic purposes and communication in general. However, it may not be taught well in English textbooks because it is a daunting task that requires learners to be familiar with content, organization, vocabulary items, and punctuation marks (Mohammed, 2019). Creative Writing is a product of creativity because its process includes productive and expressive language skills. CW activities need an ongoing process and guidance (Santosa et al., 2019). Creative writing activities help learners translate their ideas into meaningful and purposeful words, and the creative writing process involves flexibility, elaboration, proficiency, and fluency (Karuri, 2012). Starko (2010) expands on these characteristics briefly as follows: "fluency (thinking of many ideas), flexibility (thinking of different categories or points of view), originality (thinking of unusual ideas), and elaboration (adding detail to improve ideas)" (p. 127). Creative writing helps learners to express their thoughts effectively (Cramer, 2003). In other words, it is a skill that helps students to interpret their ideas in new and creative ways in writing. It can be employed in schools and universities to improve the creativity of students (Barbot et al., 2012). Imaginative thinking is the basis for creative writing as it allows learners to use their mental skills in an attempt to generate new, novel ideas, both fluently and flexibly (Chandio, et al., 2013).

Teaching Strategy

A teacher plays a crucial role in the teaching and learning process because they ensure that students receive all the necessary knowledge throughout the year by adhering to the curriculum. The main purpose of teaching at any level is to bring out a significant change in the learner (Tebabal & Kahssay, 2011). Teaching is a profession of those who impart knowledge or skill, especially in elementary, secondary, or university. According to Ayeni (2011), teaching can be defined as a systematic process of transmitting knowledge, attitudes, and skills by professional principles. There are some useful strategies students should be aware of that may contribute to the success of any given piece of creative writing, as stated by Morley (2007, p. 28): "Creative reading is the kindest favour students can do for themselves if they aspire to be a creative writer because serious writers allow themselves to be open to influence". He adds, "Writing is stronger and more focused when the students learn to think of a specific moment in time or a specific effect or image that he or she wants to use to interest and surprise their readers." The last point is providing details, which is very important for creating an image because it moves the reader away from a general idea toward a specific one. Also, teachers writing

alongside children in class increases pupils' motivation and commitment, and research suggests that young writers settle more quickly and remain focused for longer when their teachers are similarly engaged (Goouch et al., 2009; Cremin and Baker, 2010). Yeo (2007) argues that teachers who write in their personal lives develop their writing identities and transmit the benefits of such practice to their students through their teaching of writing. Only when teachers are writers themselves do they learn empathy with their pupils, enabling them to give more space to pupils and to model writing 'live' (Horner, 2010).

Primary School Pupils in Nigeria

Primary Education is the bedrock on which we build other levels of education. The National
Policy on Education (2013) refers to it as "Education given in an institution for children" normally
aged 6 - 11. This is the level that prepares pupils for Secondary Education. We must inculcate basic skills into learners as specified in the objectives. The National Policy on Education (2013) stated the objectives of primary education are to inculcate permanent literacy and numeracy and the ability to communicate effectively; to lay off a sound basis for scientific and reflective thinking; ensure citizenship education as a basis for effective participation in and contribution to the life of the society; build character and moral training and the development of sound attitudes; develop in the child the ability to adapt to his changing environment; to give the child opportunity for developing manipulative skills that will enable him to function effectively in the society within the limits of his capacity and; to provide basic tools for further educational advancement including preparation for trades and crafts of the locality.

In pupils, there is a wealth of evidence testifying to participation in creative writing's positive impact on young people, with boys, in particular, having been found to move from a position of 'antagonism' to one of 'enthusiasm and engagement' (Owen and Munden, 2010). The term 'creative writing' itself, however, is often avoided. Cremin (2012) suggests that this is because of an earlier tendency for creative writing to be seen as contrived, artificial, and "divorced from real feeling" (DES, 1975). This occurs if teachers retain "too strong a grasp on the curriculum reins" and prioritize writing instruction at the expense of developing the desire, commitment, ownership, and agency of young writers (Cremin, 2012) Writing well matters for "emotional, intellectual and social wellbeing" (Owen, 2008), and the link between writing and future success is acknowledged by most young writers (Clark and Dugdale, 2009).

Since the primary level is the cornerstone of any school, creative writing should be taken seriously starting there. Encouraging pupils to write well and think creatively from an early age will have a favourable impact on their academic development.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Antoniou and James (2014) provide one answer to the above questions: "To learn or teach how to write, learners and teachers should adopt the following techniques: first, by creating a sentence and attaching another after it, but this requires hard work and practice," and second, by imitating the great writers' description techniques." According to Gaunt and Stott (2018), students should read about how others did it first, and teachers should provide students with a giving and compelling study guide as a written resource. "To learn to write, you have to repeat the action as often as a musician or dancer does," he added.

According to James and Brookfield (2014), everyone acquires the ability to be creative; the challenge is to allow ourselves to be open to it. He explained there are many keys to remember when writing creatively: curiosity, passion, determination, awareness, energy, sensitivity, an attentive ear, and a keen eye. Creative writing has many healing properties, including the ability to reduce depression and negative thinking, improve one's self-image, and manage one's thoughts, emotions, and behaviour (Kaufman and Beghetto 2009)

Allowing students to be creative can have positive effects beyond the nuts and bolts of language acquisition. Sullivan (2015) and Bussinger (2013) have shown how creativity can empower students and lead to greater autonomy, echoing Hyland's (2019) concern that by dictating content and themes to writing students disconnect them from the subject which, in turn, has harmful effects on motivation. Maloney (2022) delves into this topic, exploring student disengagement with L2 writing on two fronts: the first reflects Hyland's (2019) and Sullivan's (2015) findings that students disconnect from the topic of their paper when they feel no ownership of it. The results of my earlier study (Maloney, 2022) showed that students believed L2 writing was difficult, boring, and not particularly useful in their language acquisition careers. The second finding from my study (Maloney, 2022) relevant here is that students suffered from a lack of self-confidence in their ability to express their ideas, emotions, and opinions in their L2.

Ings (2009) stated that "the most exciting" outcome of the 'Writing is Primary' project was that teachers developed a deeper understanding of the writing process through their practice as writers, which ultimately led to a change in the way they taught writing. Similarly, in the Big Writing project, Harland et al. found that teachers reported a range of impacts on the way they taught writing, including on their: repertoire of approaches and techniques; ability to teach writing engagingly; ideas and resources; ability to stretch and challenge pupils; subject knowledge about teaching writing; and assessment of writing (Harland et al., 2014).

Techniques for Creative Writing

Nasir, Sarwat & and Imran (2021) listed the following as the most effective methods for encouraging students to write creatively:

- First, teachers must provide clear instructions, procedures, and methods for writing processes,
- Second, students must write regularly in all subjects. as well as to help them achieve their intended goals and improve their results,
- Third, teachers should provide examples of inspiring essays in all target subjects,
- Fourth, students are sometimes confused with needs that vary from subject to subject. As a result, teachers must continue writing,
- The fifth technique is for the teacher to instruct the students to review and correct their writing to improve the accuracy of their work, which is essential for future writing progress,
- The last technique is for the teacher to provide appropriate written information about the student's mistakes to enhance the students' writing skills. Feedback is very important in correcting students' mistakes. Here are some strategies that students can learn and contribute to the creative process: "Creative lectures are the most important thing students can do if they want to be creative".

Benefits of Creative Writing for Learners

According to Alan Maley (2009), some benefits of creative writing for learners are:

• Creative writing aids language development at all levels, such as grammar, vocabulary, phonology, and discourse,

• It fosters "playfulness" which encourages learners to take risks with the language, to explore it without fear of reproof,

• Creative writing emphasizes the right side of the brain, with a focus on feelings, physical sensations, intuition, and musicality,

• Creative writing tends to develop self-confidence and self-esteem among learners,

• Creative writing leads to a corresponding growth in positive motivation,

• Creative writing feeds into more creative reading. By getting the process of creating the text, learners come to understand how such texts work instinctively, and this makes them easier to read,

• Moreover, creative writing helps to improve expository writing.

Theories of Creative Writing

Theories of creative writing provide insights on how to write different texts. The insights are explored for pedagogical purposes so that teachers can teach adequately, discrete components of the art in class. It is necessary to study theoretical literature in any field of research for illuminating perspectives. Indeed, Adonizio and Laux cited in Mary Swander et al. (2014) note that "to write without any awareness of a tradition you are trying to become part of would be self-defeating."

The John Hopkins Guide to Literary Criticism and Theory cf. Mary Swander et al. (2014) submit that literary theory "aspires, from Aristotle to Hans-George Godamer to Jacques Derrida toward a systematic statement of the principles and methods governing interpretation and evaluation…" Some of the theories of creative writing cf. Mary Swander et al. (2014) include:

i. The Romantic Myth: This theory holds the view that a writer's talent is inborn and that an individual can explore his/her latent talents in the craft through personal effort rather than expecting the craft to be taught in classroom situations. The theory emphasizes the aesthetics of writing as well as originality.
ii. Bloom and Bate Theory: The theory posits that the literary feat of predating celebrated writers threatens the efforts of contemporary and future writers to achieve originality, and the more the numerical strength of such predating great writers, the greater the threat to new writers‟ attempts to demonstrate originality.
iii. Compositional Theory: To refute the argument that writing is less difficult than literary study this school, championed by Wandy Bishop, contends that writing courses have content and writing is „important work'. They propose that creative writing should be treated in some way as composition classes, creating room for following or flouting writing conventions.
iv. Non-traditional Academic Approach: This approach advocates for the use of workshops in teaching creative writing. The students‟ works are subjected to critical evaluation.
v. Critical Theory: It teaches learners the necessity of reflecting on the process, aims, content, and style of writing as they interpret the social, philosophical, cognitive, and diachronic contexts of already published literary works. This practice helps creative writers to produce novel literature that establishes the link between the past and present.

Okpala's Personal View About Getting Positive Results with the Use of Creative Writing in the Classroom.

My expertise in teaching has increased as a result of my course studies in English education. This is because I began teaching in 2012 when I was still a student. I've come to reconcile that young people initially find writing challenging because they perceive it as a demanding task. It just didn't sit well with me that they wanted the notes to be placed in their notebooks. My students began exhibiting it, and I developed strategies to begin addressing the issue. I described it as an issue because students are losing interest in creative writing, which causes them to think slowly and score poorly on both internal and external examinations. A student needs to write well enough to be considered proficient in the language if not a high performer. I use a variety of approaches and techniques to incorporate creative

writing into my regular teaching duties. I've found that students enjoy stories a lot, which is why writing is done. I usually begin my classes with engaging stories and conclude with writing exercises. It began opening the children's minds to the possibility of learning. This is a style I have been using for years, and it is excellent. Their ability to think clearly and write quickly is also enhanced. Their confidence in writing for academic purposes and other purposes began to grow as an outcome. They were becoming more in charge of their writing. They began to think creatively and unconventionally, utilizing objects in their environment to expand their knowledge and understanding. I introduced dictation to the students as their proficiency in creative writing grew, and this caused them to write at a faster pace as well. I employed creative writing as a teaching approach to help my students grow and make positive changes, which enhanced their academic results as well. Ultimately, students' perspectives demonstrate that when they begin writing independently, their vocabulary, creativity, self-assurance, and grammar all steadily improve. Students who write creatively develop new perspectives on the world. It's a fantastic tactic that every teacher ought to implement in the classroom.

Conclusion

Finally, developing one's writing skills aids in both confidence-building and academic success. Academically and otherwise, it also sharpens one's mentality. It is impossible to overstate the wonderful effects that creative writing has on Nigerian primary school pupils' lives, and it is something that all academic fields should take seriously. Primary school education is essential for Nigeria to progress socially, economically, and technologically. Teachers should take the education of their pupils seriously, especially their writing, and remember that primary school is the cornerstone of all education. This is because teaching children to write at a young age fosters self-ownership and confidence in them that will benefit them in the future.

Suggestions

Based on the outcomes of this study, the following suggestions were made.

- Creative writing should be a compulsory subject at the primary school level. This will help the pupils to become conversant with writing.
- Teachers should create an atmosphere conducive to learning to enhance the development of students' learning experiences.
- Teachers should also increase their knowledge of various instructional strategies to keep students engaged and motivated throughout the learning process.
- Writing skills should be valued as much as other skills and be carefully studied in schools.

- Teachers should be trained to be good at creative writing, this is because when the head is faulty the whole body becomes faulty as well. Therefore, the teachers should be fluent in writing. This can be achieved by constant practice, workshops, and seminars to educate teachers to know better.
- Teachers should be patient with the learners and enable them to try to think out of the box to come to a solution for any given learning task. This will build their ownership mentality of "I CAN DO IT."

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